Women in *The Ladies' Diary*, 1704–1840

What Leybourn's four volumes and the later Diaries show

Working notes for the booklet series

October 2026, revised

The short version

The Ladies' Diary was founded in 1704 as an almanac for women. In the first twenty years women set about one question in ten. After 1724 they almost vanish as setters. Through the rest of the century a handful of women's names appear, never more than a few in a decade. By the early nineteenth century there is one.

As solvers they last longer. A small group of women answered regularly in the 1710s. Then there are very few until the 1790s, when Miss Maria Middleton and others reappear. In the 1800s Miss Mary Weston of Gainsborough answers eight questions.

After 1816, where Leybourn stops, the Diary's own pages show three more women setting questions, and a scattering of solvers: Sarah Ellis, who went on answering as Mrs Sarah Clay after her marriage; Jane Thoburn of Blyth, aged twelve; and Miss L. L., who by 1834 was among the Diary's most regular solvers. In the last issue, for 1840, no woman appears in the mathematics.

One correction comes out of this work. Leybourn's index identifies "Miss Ann Nicholls", the most prolific woman setter of the middle of the century, as a pen-name of William Wales. Wales was the astronomer who later sailed with Cook. Book Three originally treated her as a woman. It has been corrected.

Sources and method

For 1704 to 1816 everything here comes from Thomas Leybourn, *The Mathematical Questions, Proposed in the Ladies' Diary, and their Original Answers* (4 vols, London, 1817). We worked from the Internet Archive's machine-read text of all four volumes, and from a machine-read copy of the Diary for 1780. Leybourn's volumes stop in 1816. For 1816 to 1840 we worked from three bound volumes of the Diary itself: the issues for 1816–1825 and 1825–1834, digitised by Google Books, and for 1835–1840, the Harvard College Library copy digitised by HathiTrust.[1] There is no index for these years, so the names after 1816 come from reading the pages themselves, including the "also answered" lists, and they are less complete than Leybourn's for the solvers he printed. The main tool is Leybourn's *Index of the Names of the Persons who have Proposed and Answered the Questions*, at the end of volume IV. It gives, for every contributor, the questions he or she set and answered. Where the index was hard to read, we checked names against the text. The section "What we know of them" goes beyond Leybourn, and its sources are given in footnotes.

Three cautions.

1. **Pen-names.** Many contributors used pseudonyms. A woman's pen-name, such as Amanda, Rosamond or Silvia, does not prove a woman. "Ann Nicholls" shows that men did use them. Leybourn names the person behind some pseudonyms, but not all.

[1] `https://hdl.handle.net/2027/hvd.hxvmnt`.

2. **The index covers only the printed answers.** Leybourn's index lists the solvers whose answers he printed or named. The Diary itself also printed long lists of other people who "also answered". Those are not in the index. So the index undercounts women solvers. The 1780 issue, for example, names Mrs Eleanor Suggett as a solver of three questions, and she is not in the index.

3. **Only the mathematics.** Leybourn collected only the mathematical questions. The Diary's enigmas, rebuses, queries and poems, where women were far more numerous, are not in his volumes at all. Even in 1840, when no woman appears in the mathematics, about a fifth of the contributors to the enigmas were women.[2]

How many questions women set

Counting questions set under a woman's name or a woman's pen-name, prize questions included, and leaving out "Ann Nicholls":

Volume	Years	Questions	By women	Rate
I	1704–1748	about 330	11	about 1 in 30
of which 1709–1724		about 110	11	about 1 in 10
of which 1725–1748		about 220	0	none
II	1749–1776	about 430	7	about 1 in 60
III	1777–1802	about 415	5	about 1 in 80
IV	1802–1816	about 225	1	about 1 in 220
The Diary	1817–1840	about 375	4	about 1 in 95

Teri Perl made an independent count in 1979, of questions *and* answers by women, not only questions set. Albree and Brown summarise it: 42 contributions from 1710 to 1725, then a gap of 23 years, then 17 from 1748 to 1768, then only two in the next 27 years.[3] The shape is the same as ours: a strong start, a long silence, a short revival around 1750. The last row of our table counts four questions by three women: Mary Knight and Susan Jackson in 1817, and Miss L. L. in 1834 and 1836. Albree and Brown also count three women setters between 1817 and 1836. Perl's figure for 1748–1768 probably includes the "Ann Nicholls" questions, which we leave out.

Corrections made to the booklets

Book Three first said that "at least seventeen" of volume II's questions carry a woman's name, about one in twenty-four, ten of them by Ann Nicholls. It now says seven, about one in sixty, and names Wales. Its three "Nicholls" problems carry both names. The footnotes in Books Three and Four first gave "about one in ten" for volume I as a whole. They now give about one in thirty, with one in ten for 1709–1724.

Women who set questions

Name as printed	Questions	Notes
Volume I		
Lydia Fisher	Q18 (c. 1711)	Book One, "Lydia Fisher's numbers".

[2] J. Albree and S. H. Brown, "A valuable monument of mathematical genius", *Historia Mathematica* 36 (2009), 10–47, p. 32.

[3] J. Albree and S. H. Brown, "A valuable monument of mathematical genius", *Historia Mathematica* 36 (2009), p. 17, from T. Perl, *Historia Mathematica* 6 (1979).

Name as printed	Questions	Notes
Sarah Brown	Q29 (c. 1713)	Book One, "The patient lover".
Mrs Anna Wright	prize question 1713	The star nearest the pole at the Creation (astronomy). She also answered Q23 and the prize question for 1711.
Mrs Barbara Sidway	Q36 (c. 1714)	The greatest cylinder in a cone: Book One, Purple. She also answered Q17, 20, 21, 22 and two prize questions.
Mrs Boydell	Q43 (c. 1715)	Book One, "The old man's name".
Xantippe, of Helmsley	Q55 (c. 1717)	Pen-name. Book One, "The legacy".
The Lady Mer. Heyshot	Q58 (c. 1717)	Book One, "Two sons".
Mrs Mary Nelson, of Newmarket	Q72 (c. 1717)	Book One, "The prize money". She also answered several questions and the prize questions for 1714 and 1715.
Adrastea	Q89 (c. 1721), prize questions 1722 and 1724	Pen-name. Book One, "The passengers' fares". In one of her questions she drops stones into Eldon Hole, in Derbyshire, in 1718.
S. T.	Q80 (c. 1720)	Gender not stated. Not counted.
Volume II		
Amanda	Q296 (1748/9)	Pen-name. Book Three, "Always one short".
Miss Munlove (index: Manlove)	Q298 (1748/9)	Book Three, "Placing the servants" (and the grey box).
Rosamond	Q305 (1748/9)	Pen-name. Amicable numbers. Book Three, "Seven more than itself".
Miss Maria Atkinson	Q377 (1754), Q391 (1755)	Signed "Miss Maria A—i—s—n" for Q377. Q391 is her age in verse, which gives Book Three its epigraph.
Miss T. S—e	Q434 (1758)	Book Three, "Height, years and fortune".
Miss S. T.	Q463 (1760)	"Miss" in the text; Leybourn's index has only "T. S.". Book Three, "The drover's sheep".
Volume III		
Miss Nancy Mason, of Clapham, Yorkshire	Q984 (1795), Q1003 (1796), Q1018 (1797)	Her age (Book Four), the five sons' square field (Book Four), a silver vessel of wine.
Miss Sarah Cowen	Q1030 (1798), Q1059 (1800)	A field from a lost figure; tangent three times sine (Book Four).
Volume IV		
Mrs Macdonald, of Spindlestone	Q1098 (1802)	The falling ball of cork. Leybourn's index has "Macdonal, J." (*Beyond A-level*).
The Diaries for 1816–1825 (not in Leybourn)		
Miss Mary Knight, of Boston	Q1314 (1817)	Cone with slant 10; she answered it herself (*After Leybourn*).
Miss Susan Jackson, of Mile End	Q1316 (1817)	Two balls from a tower (*After Leybourn*).
The Diaries for 1826–1834 (not in Leybourn)		
Miss L. L.	Q1577 (1834)	The largest circle in a triangle cut from a semicircle. Her own answer, printed in 1835, is exactly right (*The Gregory years*).
The Diaries for 1835–1840 (not in Leybourn)		

Name as printed	Questions	Notes
Miss L. L.	Q1608 (1836)	Also Q1577 above. Q1608 is the shortest route from London to Constantinople touching the equator (*The last years*).

Women who answered

Up to 1816, taken from Leybourn's index; the Diary's own "also answered by" lists, which are not indexed, would add more. After 1816, taken from the Diary's pages, lists included.

Name as printed	Answers	Notes
Volume I		
A Lady	Q6	"Solution by a Lady", the earliest in the volume.
Mrs Mary Wright	Q16, prize 1710	Book One, introduction.
Mrs Barbara Sidway	Q17, 20, 21, 22, two prize questions	Also a setter.
Mrs Anna Wright	Q23, prize 1711	Also a setter.
Mrs Mary Nelson	several, prize questions 1714, 1715	Also a setter.
Mrs Morgan	prize 1714	
Silvia	Q41, 44, 45, 46	Pen-name.
Hesychia	Q49, 67	Pen-name.
Mrs Adway	Q56	
Anna Philomathes	Q59, 62, 63, 64	Pen-name.
Sylvia	Q93, 107	Pen-name, perhaps the same person as Silvia.
Eliz. Dod	one question, about Q95	The number is hard to read in the index.
Adrastea	prize 1722	Also a setter.
A Lady, Grubean	Q170	
Volume II		
Miss E. S.	Q391	She answered Miss Atkinson's age question.
Amaryllis	Q462	Pen-name. The question was "Ann Nicholls"s, that is, William Wales's.
The Diary for 1780 (not in the index)		
Mrs Eleanor Suggett	Q742, 743, 746	In the "also answered" lists.
Mrs Jane Roberts	prize enigma	Won ten Diaries; set and answered rebuses.
Miss Diana Browne	prize enigma	Won eight Diaries.
Miss Nancy —	rebuses	Answered in verse.
Volume III		
Miss Betty Claxton, of Benwell	Q909	First printed answer to the window and the wall (Book Four).
Miss Maria Middleton, of Eden, near Durham	Q1002, 1014, 1017, 1041	Including the three heights of a triangle (Book Four).
Miss M. Castieau, of Shropshire	Q1059	Answered Miss Cowen's question.
Volume IV		

Name as printed	Answers	Notes
Miss Mary Weston, of Gainsborough	Q1195, 1210, 1231, 1247, 1258, 1286, 1291, 1294	The most persistent woman solver in the collection after 1720.
Miss Susan (Susannah) Jackson, of Mile End	Q1241, 1254, 1269 and one more	
Mrs Elizabeth Bryhon, of Helmsley	Q1157	
The Diaries for 1816–1825 (not in Leybourn)		
Miss Mary Knight	Q1299 (her solution printed, 1817), Q1314, and several in 1818	
Miss Susan Jackson	several, 1817–1818	Also a solver in Leybourn's vol. IV.
Miss Mary R—e; Miss Mary West	1818 lists	"West" may be Mary Weston.
Miss Clara Clay	Q1391 (1823)	
Miss Sarah Ellis, later Mrs Sarah Clay	Q1406 (1824); Q1423, Q1429 (1825)	Printed in 1825 as "Mrs. Sarah Clay (formerly Miss S. Ellis)".
The Diaries for 1826–1834 (not in Leybourn)		
Mrs S. Clay, of Moulton	at least nine questions in 1828, including Q1465	Almost certainly Sarah Ellis, above.
Miss Jane Thoburn, of Blyth	Q1479 (1829)	First printed answer, "aged 12 years". A Mary Thoburn and a Miss Thoburn appear in the lists of the same years (*The Gregory years*).
Miss L. L.	Q1557 and at least seven others (1834)	Her solution to Q1557 is printed first. A footnote to Q1566 compares her with Agnesi and Mrs Somerville.
The Diaries for 1835–1840 (not in Leybourn)		
Miss L. L.	Q1599, 1601, 1606, 1607 (all 1837), probably 1604 and 1608	Also answered two of the Diary's queries in 1837.
Mary Forster	Q1599 (1837), perhaps another with J. Forster	

What we know of them

For almost all of these women the Diary is the only record. Leybourn gives a name and sometimes a town, and nothing more. Three cases are worth setting out.

Miss Nancy Mason, of Clapham

Her Clapham is the village under Ingleborough in the Yorkshire Dales, not Clapham in London. Sylvia Harrop went looking for her in 2010.[4]

Nancy first appears in the Diary in 1792, aged about nineteen, and is there every year until 1798. Then she disappears. Her question of 1795 asks for her own age on 1 January of that year, and

[4] S. Harrop, "The Enigma of Miss Nancy Mason of Clapham, Eighteenth Century Mathematician Extraordinaire", *North Craven Heritage Trust Journal* (2010). Online at `http://settle.ddns.net/NCHTJ2010/2010/NancyMason.html`. Everything in this subsection is from Harrop, except where noted.

the answer is 21 years, 11 months and 7 days. That puts her birth in late January 1773.[5] She was not only a mathematician. She wrote verse charades and long answers to the Diary's "queries", on whether a virtuous old maid or a young widow would make the more charming wife, and on the origin of valentines. In 1793 she shared a prize with the Reverend Mr Ewbank, six Diaries each. In 1796 Ewbank printed a poem to her, offering, half in jest, to "tie the knot" if he visited. A modern reader, Mike Slater, judged her mathematics to be at about today's A-level standard.

The parish registers of Clapham, Giggleswick and Bentham have no baptism or burial for her, and the Quaker records have nothing either. Harrop concludes that she was not from the district. Her guess is that Nancy was staying with relatives or friends of her family, probably a well-off or clerical one. A Mason family lived at Newby, close by, and its son James was almost exactly her age. A "Mr James Mason of Clapham" answered one Diary question, in 1800. Harrop considers whether "Nancy Mason" was a pen-name and rejects it: by the 1790s women had no need to hide.

Why did she stop? Harrop's likeliest answer is marriage, at about twenty-five. The Diary itself had remarked in 1792 on three "fair and ingenious sisters" who stopped writing one by one as each married. It may be the commonest ending in this whole dossier. We simply cannot see it.

Mary Wright and Mary Nelson

Albree and Brown print a suggestion that Mrs Mary Nelson of Newmarket, who set the prize-money question in 1719, was Mary Wright under her married name.[6] The suggestion was Shelley Costa's, made tentatively in her doctoral dissertation (Cornell, 2000). She has since found evidence that disproves it, and has told us so: they were two different women.[7] We repeat the point here only because the published version is wrong.

Costa's dissertation also identifies Mary and Anna Wright, who were sisters, and locates Barbara Sidway, from parish and county records in England. That work is unpublished, and we do not draw on it here.

Elizabeth Beighton

She set and answered nothing that we can find, but for sixteen years the Diary was hers. Even before Henry Beighton died, Charles Hutton wrote in 1775, the mathematical part was composed by his friend Anthony Thacker, while "the enigmatical parts were managed by his amiable wife". When Henry died in 1743, Elizabeth carried the Diary on as his widow, and the Stationers' Company recognised her as its "author" throughout her widowhood, until her death in 1759. She edited the enigmas herself. For the mathematics, and for the astronomy an almanac needs, she relied on others: first Thacker, who died in 1744, then Robert Heath, who ran the mathematics from 1745 until the Company dismissed him in 1753, then Thomas Simpson. The histories written afterwards, from Hutton's own onwards, gave the dates of the men and left her out, and so made her part look marginal.[8] So a woman ran the Diary through the very years when, as the table above shows, women had stopped setting its questions.

[5] Our arithmetic, not Harrop's.

[6] J. Albree and S. H. Brown, "A valuable monument of mathematical genius", *Historia Mathematica* 36 (2009), 10–47, p. 17.

[7] S. Costa, personal communication, October 2026.

[8] S. A. Costa, *The Ladies' Diary: Society, Gender and Mathematics in England, 1704–1754*, PhD dissertation, Cornell University (2000), pp. 324–327, quoting C. Hutton, *The Diarian Miscellany* (London, 1775), vol. I, preface, p. v, and H. Ellis (ed.), *Letters of Eminent Literary Men* (London, 1843), p. 304. Thacker's death in 1744 is from R. and P. Wallis (eds), *Index of British Mathematicians, Part III, 1701–1800* (Newcastle upon Tyne, 1993), p. 135, cited by Costa (p. 327, n. 25). The points on the enigmas and on her reliance on Thacker and Heath are confirmed by Costa, personal communication, October 2026. J. Albree and S. H. Brown, "A valuable monument of mathematical genius", *Historia Mathematica* 36 (2009), Table 1, list her as an editor for 1744 only.

The rest

For the others we found nothing outside the Diary. ProofWiki says of Barbara Sidway only that "little is known" about her. The published studies (Perl, Costa's *Osiris* article, Albree and Brown, Swetz) treat the women as a group. The one sustained attempt to trace them in the records is Costa's dissertation, mentioned above, which is unpublished. The towns the Diary gives are the place to begin, as Harrop began with Clapham:

Name	Town as printed
Mrs Mary Nelson	Newmarket
Xantippe	Helmsley
Miss Betty Claxton	Benwell
Miss Maria Middleton	Eden, near Durham
Miss M. Castieau	Shropshire
Miss Diana Browne	Honiton (1780)
Mrs Macdonald	Spindlestone, near Bamburgh
Miss Mary Weston	Gainsborough
Miss Susan Jackson	Mile End
Mrs Elizabeth Bryhon	Helmsley

Castieau and Bryhon are rare surnames. The parish registers for those places may well find them.

Pen-names, and the case of Ann Nicholls

"Miss Ann Nicholls" (also printed Nichols and Anna Nicholls) set ten questions between 1760 and 1768: 462, 475, 487, 516, 527, 543, 551, 556, 567 and 586. Most are astronomy: sunrise at two towns, a lunar eclipse, the Pleiades and Aldebaran in one vertical circle. Leybourn's index lists her as "Nichols, Ann. (Mr. W. Wales)". William Wales (c. 1734–1798) was the astronomer on Cook's second voyage. He later became master of the Royal Mathematical School at Christ's Hospital. The index gives him several other pseudonyms: Nauticus, Geometricus, Gemini and G. Cetii.

Leybourn knew many of these contributors, and his identifications elsewhere check out. He names Thomas Simpson as Hurlothrumbo, Kubernetes and Patrick O'Cavanah, and Landen as Peter Puzzlem. So his word should be taken. The ten "Ann Nicholls" questions are a man's, written under a woman's name.

It cuts both ways. The female pen-names of the early volumes, Xantippe, Adrastea, Silvia, Hesychia and Anna Philomathes, may also hide men. Leybourn identifies none of them, and the early Diary had a real community of women contributors to draw on, so most are probably genuine. But the count of women setters is best read as an upper bound for pen-names and a lower bound for women overall. Some women surely signed with initials or men's names.

One pen-name is missing from Leybourn altogether. Albree and Brown note that Beighton answered a "Blowzabella" as a woman in 1726, and that she won a prize for one of her mathematical answers in 1740.[9] She is not in Leybourn's index, which supports the second caution above: the index undercounts the women solvers.

[9] J. Albree and S. H. Brown, "A valuable monument of mathematical genius", *Historia Mathematica* 36 (2009), 10–47, p. 17, citing the Diary for 1726, p. 20, and 1740, p. 40.

The pattern

- **1709–1724.** Women both set and answer. Barbara Sidway, Mary Nelson and the two Wrights appear repeatedly. Several questions are about the women themselves: their ages, their fortunes, their suitors.
- **1725–1748.** No question in Leybourn's first volume is set by a woman after Adrastea's prize question of 1724. The mathematics grows harder: fluxions, curves, mechanics. The named contributors are now mostly schoolmasters, surveyors and excisemen.
- **1748–1776.** A short revival as the second volume opens (Amanda, Miss Munlove, Rosamond), then Miss Atkinson, Miss T. S—e and Miss S. T. Their questions are mostly arithmetic in verse.
- **1777–1802.** Miss Nancy Mason and Miss Sarah Cowen set questions. Women solvers return in the 1790s: Miss Betty Claxton, Miss Maria Middleton, Miss Castieau.
- **1802–1816.** One setter, Mrs Macdonald. But Miss Mary Weston answers eight questions, more than any woman since 1720.
- **After Leybourn, 1817–1840.** Albree and Brown know of only three women who set mathematical questions between 1817 and 1836, and none after. In the last issue, for 1840, no woman appears in the mathematics at all. Two newly found volumes add names. The issues for 1816–1825 have Mary Knight and Susan Jackson setting questions, and five or six women answering, among them Sarah Ellis, who went on answering after her marriage, as Mrs Sarah Clay.[10] The issues for 1826–1834 add Miss Jane Thoburn of Blyth, who in 1829, "aged 12 years", has the first printed answer to a question, and show Mrs Clay still answering in 1828. By 1834 Miss L. L. is answering in quantity. Her solution to Question 1557 is printed first, and against her name in the list of solvers of Question 1566 the editor put a footnote: "We admire the talents of our fair correspondent. If she will only make up her mind to carry her own solutions through, instead of referring to Simpson, Hymer, &c. she may soon vie with Donna Agnesi, and our own Mrs. Somerville."[11] The bound volume of the last six issues at Harvard adds another: a Miss L. L., who set questions in 1834 and 1836 and was among the most regular solvers of 1837. She is probably one of Albree and Brown's three, though they mention her only once, as one of seven solvers credited for a single answer. Mary Forster answered in 1837. In the enigmas, rebuses and verse of the same issues, women are everywhere.[12]

Further reading

J. Albree and S. H. Brown, "A valuable monument of mathematical genius": *The Ladies' Diary* (1704–1840), *Historia Mathematica* 36 (2009).

T. Perl, The *Ladies' Diary* or Woman's Almanack, 1704–1841, *Historia Mathematica* 6 (1979).

S. Costa, The *Ladies' Diary*: Gender, Mathematics, and Civil Society in Early-Eighteenth-Century England, *Osiris* 17 (2002).

S. A. Costa, *The Ladies' Diary: Society, Gender and Mathematics in England, 1704–1754*, PhD dissertation, Cornell University (2000).

[10] *The Ladies' Diary* for 1816–1825, digitised by Google Books.

[11] *The Ladies' Diary* for 1825–1834, digitised by Google Books; the note is in the issue for 1834.

[12] *The Ladies' Diary* for 1835–1840, Harvard College Library copy, digitised by HathiTrust, `https://hdl.handle.net/2027/hvd.hxvmnt`; Albree and Brown, p. 28, n. 27.

F. J. Swetz, *The Impact and Legacy of The Ladies' Diary (1704–1840): A Woman's Declaration* (MAA Press, 2021), especially the chapter "Women and the Diary".

S. Harrop, "The Enigma of Miss Nancy Mason of Clapham", *North Craven Heritage Trust Journal* (2010).